

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

This work is an adaptation of Tyndale Open Study Notes © 2023 Tyndale House Publishers, licensed under the CC BY-SA 4.0 license. The adaptation, Aquifer Open Study Notes, was created by Mission Mutual and is also licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0.

This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

U

Understanding Job

The story of Job presents a tension between good and bad aspects of his character. The beginning of the book clearly approves of Job (Job 1:1, 8; 2:3). But later, God questions Job directly: “Who is this who obscures My counsel by words without knowledge?” (38:2). “Would you really annul My justice? Would you condemn Me to justify yourself?” (40:8).

Some interpreters think Job talks too much and confuses God’s work with Satan’s. Some modern interpreters blame Job for his suffering, agreeing with his friends. Others argue like Eliphaz and Elihu (5:17–27; 33:15–33; 36:7–17). They say that Job’s suffering is God’s loving discipline. Even God’s faithful encounter such discipline (Hebrews 12:6–12; see Proverbs 3:11–12). But this idea contradicts the book’s opening statement.

Job suffered because God wanted to show Satan that Job was honest and faithful. God always had a positive view of Job’s life (Job 1:1, 8; 2:3; 42:7). This idea continues in the New Testament, where Job is an example of patience we should follow (James 5:11).

Job’s reactions are normal. He does not remain firm. His trials affected him. He also does not boldly defy his troubles as if they cannot affect him. He reacts like any human would.

Job becomes angry, protests, complains, and goes back and forth between confidence and despair. But he never gives up hope. He does not curse God or falsely confess guilt, trying to influence God to remove his suffering. Although Job cannot understand his situation, he knows his answer will come from God (Job 19:25–27).

Passages for Further Study

Job 1:1, 8; 2:3; 5:17–18; 19:25–27; 33:15–28; 36:8–15; 38:2; 40:8; 42:7; Proverbs 3:11; Hebrews 12:7, 10; James 5:11

The Unknown God

The apostle Paul spoke to the Areopagus, the high council of the city of Athens (Acts 17:19). He spoke to people who did not share his belief in the God of Abraham and Moses. This God had revealed himself, “On many past occasions and in many different ways... through the prophets” (Hebrews 1:1).

Paul’s audience thought differently about religion than he did. They had many gods in their culture, and common people still believed in the ancient gods. Yet,

many of the people who influenced the culture of Athens no longer believed the gods existed. Instead, they followed either materialism (the belief that only physical things exist) or pantheism (the belief that the divine is in everything).

They all lacked the belief in one true God who is Lord of all. Their myths described the actions of various gods, but they did not believe that the ultimate reality, God himself, could be known. Instead, they reasoned and discussed the latest ideas, hoping to better understand the nature of things.

When Paul visited Athens, many philosophical ideas were popular. Yet, Stoicism and Epicureanism were the two main schools of thought (Acts 17:18).

Stoicism was founded by Zeno of Citium, who lived from around 334 to 262 BC. Those who followed the teachings of Stoicism were called Stoics. The Stoics studied nature’s laws and believed in the Logos, a force that organizes and sustains everything. This force gives life and reason to humans. A good life is one where reason leads, and peace of mind and harmony with nature exist. Many important ancient leaders were Stoics or influenced by Stoicism. This included Cicero, Seneca, and Marcus Aurelius. Some Christians found Stoic ideas appealing because of similarities between the Stoic Logos and the divine Logos and between natural law and God’s law (John 1:1–18).

The Epicureans were people who followed the teachings of Epicurus, who lived from 341 to 270 BC. They were empiricists, which means they believed knowledge comes from what we can experience with our senses (like seeing, hearing, or touching) rather than from abstract reasoning. Epicureans focused on natural evidence and showed little interest in mathematics. Their main interest was ethics, the study of right behavior (morality). They judged actions or things by the pleasure or pain they caused. Epicurus viewed belief in gods as a threat to peace of mind. He and his followers believed that no one should fear either gods or death.

When Paul spoke, he used their poets to explain complex ideas. He said that the God who created everything is personal and able to be known. God showed himself clearly, in real history, and in a complete way in Jesus Christ. After death, there is not an end or a journey of the soul, but only coming judgment. The resurrection of Jesus from the dead proves all these things.

Most Greeks in Athens thought it was foolish, but it is the ultimate truth. God can be known through Jesus Christ.

Passages for Further Study

Psalm 50:7–15; Isaiah 42:5–7; Acts 17:16–32; Romans 1:18–32; Colossians 1:15–23; Colossians 2:6–12; 1 Thessalonians 1:9–10; Hebrews 1:1–4